THE BATTLE OF DAN-NO-URA

By 1185 the Gempei Wars, in which the Minamoto and Taira clans fought for control of Japan, had turned decisively in favour of the Minamoto. The Taira had possession of the child emperor Antoku and the sacred imperial treasure, but they were on the run from the samurai Minamoto Yoshitsune after being driven from their fortress of Ichi-no-Tani in March 1184. The Taira only escaped massacre at Ichi-no-Tani by taking to their boats. Yoshitsune pursued them by sea, driving them from an anchorage at Yashima later in the same year. In April 1185 he caught up with them again in the strait of Shimonoseki between Honshu and Kyushu.

The vessels employed by both sides in the battle were oared galleys, carrying samurai armed with bows, swords, and daggers. The Taira were outnumbered but had the advantage of familiarity with local weather and tides. They adopted a well-organized formation in three squadrons, while the Minamoto came forward in a single line abreast. Like a Japanese land battle at this period, the combat began with a long-range archery duel, in which the splendidly armoured samurai competed to show off their prowess with the bow—then the most prestigious samurai weapon rather than the sword.

Taira commander Tomomori was waiting for an ebb tide to flow in mid-morning, which would aid his oarsmen. With the help of the tide, his three squadrons maneuvered to surround the Minamoto fleet on three sides and engage at close quarters. Soon ships were grappled and samurai fought samurai with sword and dagger. Men armed with hooks or rakes—perhaps grappling implements—used them to pull enemy warriors into the water. Archers targeted helmsmen and rowers, hoping to immobilize ships or put them out of control by disabling the crew.



Suicide of Taira no Tomori
Tomomori (center) has tied himself to an anchor before throwing himself into the sea, accompanied by one of his retainers (left) and his mistress (right).

THE TAIRA BETRAYED

The battle was evenly poised until two events—one predictable, the other not—swung the balance. The tide turned, giving the advantage formerly enjoyed by the Taira to their opponents. And one of the Taira commanders, Taguchi Shigeyoshi, suddenly defected and attacked his own side. More important than his contribution to the fighting was information he brought with him. The Taira had concealed the child emperor, his female relatives, and the sacred treasure on an unremarkable ship. Shigeyoshi indicated which vessel this was. The Minamoto closed in to capture this most valuable of prizes.

The end of the battle is the stuff of legend. Facing certain defeat, the Taira apparently chose mass suicide rather than captivity. Taira no Tomomori set the example in spectacular fashion, jumping into the sea tied to an anchor, which carried him to the bottom. The emperor's grandmother Taira no Tokiko took her six-year-old grandson in her arms and leapt into the sea. The Taira also tried to throw the imperial crown jewels overboard, but the ultimate fate of the sacred treasures—a sword, a mirror, and a necklace—remains a mystery. The sea was red with blood and, we are told, with dye from the Taira banners.

The battle of Dan-no-Ura brought the Gempei Wars to an end, enabling the Minamoto to establish a shogunate, a form of government that was to persist in Japan in various forms until the mid-19th century.

GEMPEI WARS



THE BATTLE OF DAN-NO-URA

Date	25 April 1185
Location	Strait of Shimonoseki
Result	Minamoto victory

COMBATANTS

MINAMOTO CLAN	TAIRA CLAN

COMMANDERS

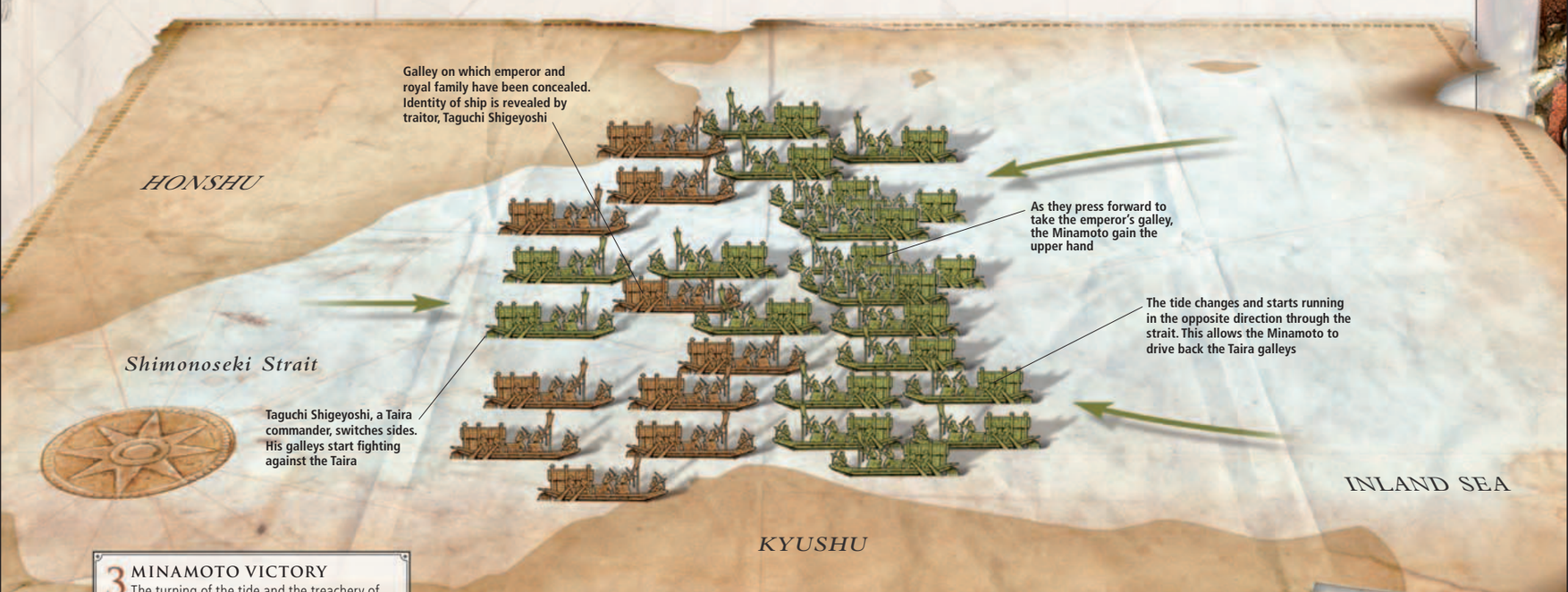
Minamoto Yoshitsune	Taira no Tomomori

FORCES

Ships: 850	**Ships:** 500

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** unknown	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** unknown



3 MINAMOTO VICTORY
The turning of the tide and the treachery of Taguchi Shigeyoshi change the course of the battle. The Minamoto start to overwhelm the Taira galleys and, when Taira no Tomomori and the emperor's family commit suicide, the battle comes to an end.